

SIPRA DAS



7 LALU PRASAD YADAV 57, RAILWAYS MINISTER (3)

MASS MAGICIAN

BECAUSE he has scripted one of the biggest success stories of the UPA Government—when he took over, the Indian Railways was on the verge of collapse with a fund balance of just Rs 350 crore, but its coffers are now overflowing, with reserves crossing Rs 13,500 crore. Because despite the carefully cultivated country bumpkin image, he is a suave politician. Because his clout with the UPA chairperson is the envy of even Congress leaders. Because he can connect with the cowbelt and CEOs alike.

SMART GUY MOVE: Met activist Medha Patkar on a train and gave her a two-year rail pass. Has given away 119 rail passes, 57 to poets and artistes.

SHOULD BE EMBARRASSED ABOUT: His public

declarations of loyalty to Sonia Gandhi.

TIT FOR TAT: When a chapter on him was deleted from Bihar textbooks, he said he'd write on how Nitish Kumar had moved from being a socialist to a friend of BJP.

AFTER LALU DOLLS AND LALU CHALISA, NOW THERE'S A DATING SITE, WWW.LALOORABRI.COM.

8 NARENDRA MODI 57, CHIEF MINISTER, GUJARAT (NEW)

THE RIGHT MASCOT

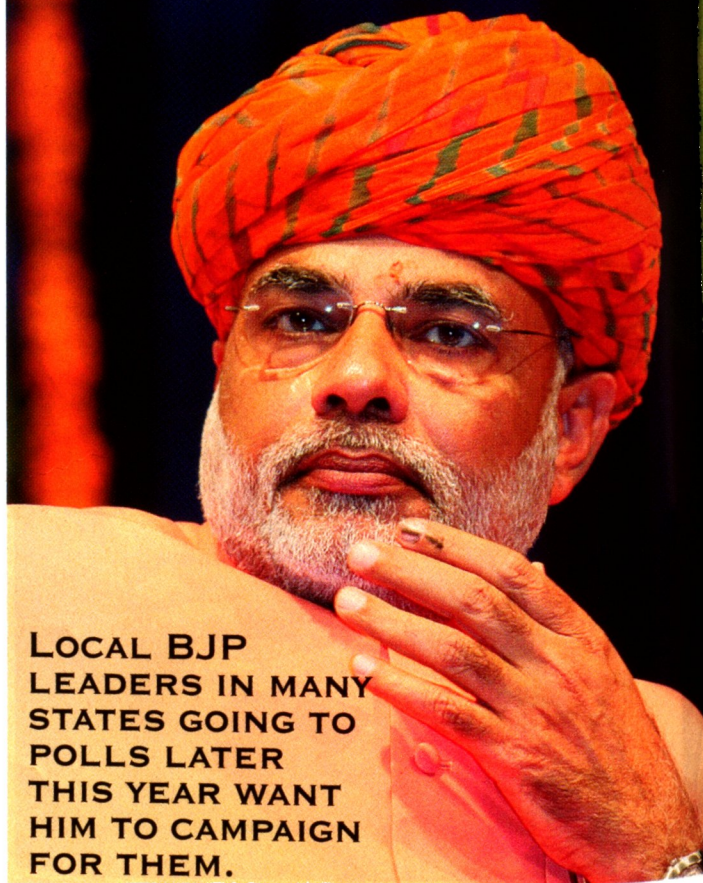
BECAUSE he is one chief minister whose presence is now truly pan-Indian. Because he challenged the secular consensus singlehandedly and won, blending his party's ideology with his own obsession with development and good governance. Because after Gujarat 2007, which coincided with Atal Bihari Vajpayee retreating from public life, he is not only seen as Hindutva's new poster boy but also BJP's mascot. Because he does what he says. Because he flaunts what he has, like his Cartier sunglasses and Mont Blanc pens.

STRONG POINT: Zero tolerance for corruption. He is so hands-on that he often invites charges of being autocratic.

REGRET: Says he has none but even if

he has, will not admit it.

LITTLE KNOWN FACT: You can download ringtones and screensavers from his website, which he personally updates every day.



LOCAL BJP LEADERS IN MANY STATES GOING TO POLLS LATER THIS YEAR WANT HIM TO CAMPAIGN FOR THEM.

SHAILESH RAVAL